

MAL CFO Founding Circle -- Master Execution Plan

Prepared: June 2026 | Internal Use Only Goal: Convert 80 CFOs into Mal SME product sign-ups and design partners

I. STRATEGIC FRAMING

The Core Thesis

Mal is not selling a bank account. Mal is selling *operating system status* -- the position of being the single platform a CFO opens every morning instead of toggling between 10 tools. The CFO Founding Circle is the acquisition engine that makes this happen by flipping the traditional sales funnel: instead of pitching to CFOs, you *recruit* them as co-creators, and the product sale becomes a byproduct of belonging.

Why This Works (Research-Backed)

- **B2B fintech buying committees average 7.4 stakeholders** with the CFO holding veto power. A community model bypasses the committee entirely -- the CFO becomes your internal champion because they helped build it.
- **Hosted roundtables of 8-12 senior finance leaders** compress trust-building timelines dramatically vs. any other channel (conference booths, cold outreach, digital ads).
- **32% of GCC businesses still lack access to Sharia-compliant banking options** -- this is not a niche, it is a structural market gap that Mal is uniquely positioned to fill.
- **The CFO SaaS + fintech convergence** (see Xero's \$3B Melio acquisition) proves the market is moving toward unified platforms. Mal is ahead of this curve for the GCC.

Competitive Landscape -- Who You're Displacing

Competitor	What they offer	What they DON'T offer (Mal's edge)
Wio Bank	Digital SME accounts, 120K+ biz clients	No Islamic-native architecture, no invoice financing, no payroll
Mashreq Neo Biz	Digital onboarding, cards	No credit products, no compliance suite, no AI agents
Zand	Digital corporate banking	Conventional-first, Islamic as add-on; no SME OS
Liv (Emirates NBD)	Retail-heavy, some SME	No receivables/payables financing, no global payroll
Traditional Islamic banks (ADIB, DIB)	Full Islamic banking	Legacy systems, slow onboarding, no integrated ops platform

Mal's moat: Nobody has built the complete Islamic-native SME operating system -- banking + credit + payroll + compliance + AI suite in one platform.

II. THE 10-WEEK COHORT MODEL -- 5 GROUPS OF 16 CFOs

Based on your requirement to split 80 CFOs into 5 groups over 10 weeks, here is the phased structure:

Cohort Structure

Cohort	Weeks	CFO Count	Sector Focus	Conversion Goal
Alpha	Weeks 1-2	16	Construction & Real Estate	Waitlist + design partnership
Beta	Weeks 3-4	16	Trading & Logistics	Waitlist + invoice financing pilot
Gamma	Weeks 5-6	16	Healthcare & Energy	Waitlist + payroll demo
Delta	Weeks 7-8	16	Tech & Professional Services	Waitlist + AI suite preview
Epsilon	Weeks 9-10	16	F&B, Retail, Hospitality + Mixed	Waitlist + full platform walkthrough

Why Cohorts, Not One Big Event

- Intimacy drives conversion.** 16 CFOs in a room is a dinner, not a conference. Every person gets face time with Abdallah and Vishnu.
- Sector-specific pain points.** A construction CFO's invoice problem is nothing like a healthcare CFO's insurance receivables gap. Tailored sessions convert better.
- Social proof compounds.** Cohort Alpha's sign-ups become testimonial content for Cohort Beta's invitations. By Epsilon, you have 64 Founding CFOs already on the wall.
- Operational feasibility.** Marketing, product demos, and 1-on-1 design partnership slots are manageable at 16, impossible at 80 simultaneously.

Each Cohort Session Format (Half-Day)

Time	Activity	Purpose
08:30	Curated breakfast (sector-tagged name badges)	Peer networking, warm-up
09:00	Abdallah keynote (15 min) -- tailored to sector	Vision + product reveal
09:20	Panel: 2 CFOs from the sector discuss real pain	Credibility, not pitching
10:00	Crisis Simulation using Mal tools	Hands-on product experience
10:30	Founding Member sign-up (iPads, live wall)	Conversion moment
11:00	1-on-1 Advisory Council recruitment (3-4 slots)	Design partnerships signed
11:30	Close: CFO Community + Startup Grant announcement	Long-term retention hook

III. ANSWERING YOUR 8 CRITICAL QUESTIONS

1. Is it realistic to assume conversion will happen at the event? How do we guarantee it?

Yes, but only if the funnel is engineered before the event, not during it.

How to guarantee conversion: - **Pre-qualification:** Every invited CFO must have a confirmed pain point that Mal solves (identified during the invitation call). No "awareness" attendees. - **Commitment escalation:** The invitation itself is positioned as exclusive selection ("You are one of 16 CFOs chosen to shape GCC SME finance"). Saying yes to the invite is the first micro-commitment. - **Friction removal:** iPads pre-loaded with waitlist form at every seat. The sign-up takes 90 seconds. QR codes on table cards as backup. - **Social pressure (positive):** The live "Founding CFOs" wall populates in real time. Nobody wants to be the only person in a room of 16 who didn't sign. - **Immediate value exchange:** Signing up unlocks Founding Member status (permanent badge, early access, quarterly previews). It is not "joining a waitlist" -- it is claiming a title. - **Post-event same-day follow-up:** Vishnu's team sends a personalized recap within 4 hours with their Founding Member confirmation and next steps.

Target: 90-100% sign-up rate per cohort. Realistic if every attendee is pre-qualified.

2. E-invoicing is a popular feature right now -- how do we incorporate?

This is a massive opportunity. The UAE e-invoicing mandate is coming and most SMEs are unprepared.

Key facts: - UAE e-invoicing mandate pilot begins **July 2026** - Large businesses (revenue $\geq$ AED 50M) must appoint an Accredited Service Provider by **October 2026** - **SMEs must be compliant by July 2027** -- which feels far away to most CFOs but requires system changes NOW - Penalties: AED 5,000/month for failing to appoint an ASP, AED 100 per non-compliant document - All B2B invoices must be structured XML (PINT AE format) via Peppol network -- PDFs and paper will no longer be valid

How to incorporate into the CFO Founding Circle:

1. **Make e-invoicing compliance a panel topic in Cohort Beta (Trading & Logistics)** -- these businesses issue the highest invoice volumes and will be hit hardest.
2. **Position Mal's Cash My Invoice / Pay My Invoice as the compliance bridge:** "You need to move to e-invoicing anyway. With Mal, you get compliance AND financing on those invoices. Two problems, one platform."
3. **Create a "UAE E-Invoicing Readiness Scorecard"** that CFOs can take during the crisis simulation. Show them where their business stands. Fear of non-compliance is a powerful motivator.
4. **Content play:** Dedicate one Mal Show episode (or a bonus mini-episode) to e-invoicing. Youssef Salem's ADNOC supply chain perspective makes it credible for large enterprises, then bridge to how SMEs in the supply chain are affected.
5. **Post-event nurture:** Send every signed CFO a "Your E-Invoicing Compliance Timeline" personalized to their business size. Mal becomes the trusted advisor before it becomes the bank.

3. How do we partner with accounting firms (EY, McKinsey, etc.)? ONLY the audit partners.

Strategy: Position Mal as a referral channel, not a competitor.

Audit partners at Big 4 firms care about three things: (a) client retention, (b) advisory upsell, (c) not being disrupted. Here is how to engage them:

Tier 1 -- Immediate (Pre-Event) - Invite 2-3 audit partners as **panelists or "knowledge partners"** at specific cohort sessions. They get stage time and access to 16 qualified CFOs. In exchange, Mal gets their endorsement and introductions. - Target: EY and PwC have the largest Islamic finance advisory practices in the UAE. Deloitte runs the "Fast 50" SME growth ranking (as Amine noted). Start with their audit partners who serve SME/mid-market clients.

Tier 2 -- Co-Branded Content - Co-author a **"GCC CFO Impact Report"** with one Big 4 firm. They provide the research credibility, Mal provides the platform data and distribution. This becomes the intellectual anchor for the CFO Community.

- Tie this to e-invoicing: "EY x Mal: Are UAE SMEs Ready for E-Invoicing?" -- the audit partners get qualified leads, Mal gets authority.

Tier 3 -- Ecosystem Integration - Build a **"Mal Certified Advisor"** program where audit partners can recommend Mal to their SME clients and receive co-marketing benefits (not commissions -- that creates compliance issues). - Position it as: "Your clients are going to need a digital banking platform that works with your audit workflows. Mal's API gives you direct visibility. Let's make the transition seamless."

Key contact approach: Do NOT go through firm BD teams. Abdallah or Vishnu should reach out directly to specific audit partners via LinkedIn or warm introductions. The CFO Community itself is the bait -- "We have 80 qualified CFOs in our community. Would you like to co-host a session?"

4. How do we highlight positioning: "We're selecting 50 CFOs to shape the future of SME finance in the GCC. You're one of them."

Update the number to 80 (matching your actual target) and deploy across three channels:

Invitation Sequence: - **Week -6:** Personal email from Abdallah (not marketing). Subject: "A seat at the table -- for 80 CFOs building the future of GCC finance." No product mention. Pure exclusivity. - **Week -4:** Follow-up from Vishnu with specifics: cohort assignment, sector focus, who else is in the room (with permission). Social proof. - **Week -2:** Final confirmation with logistics + "What to expect as a Founding Member" one-pager.

Messaging Framework: - Never say "event" or "conference" externally. Always: **"The Mal Founding Circle"** or **"Selection Round [Alpha/Beta/etc.]"** - Never say "you're invited." Say: **"You've been selected."** - Never say "sign up for our product." Say: **"Claim your Founding Member status."**

Visual Identity: - Physical invitation (not just email) -- embossed card, Mal branding, hand-signed by Abdallah. This signals "you matter" in a way a Calendly link never will. - Founding Member wall at each cohort event that carries forward -- Cohort Beta sees Alpha's names already on the wall. Momentum is visible.

5. Splitting CFOs into 5 groups over 10 weeks -- making this crystal clear

See Section II above for the full cohort model.

Additional clarity on logistics: - **Weeks 1-10 = August through mid-October 2025** (2 weeks per cohort, with sessions on the same day of week for consistency) - **The September "main event" from the original brief becomes Cohort Gamma or Delta** -- the midpoint where momentum is highest - **Cohort Epsilon (final)** is the victory lap: all previous Founding CFOs are invited back for a combined closing dinner where the full launch is teased - **Each cohort gets its own private WhatsApp/Signal group** immediately after the session -- this is the community glue

6. Payroll as a retail banking bridge (employees paid into Mal accounts)

This is the single most scalable growth lever in the entire plan.

Here is how to execute:

For the CFO (business side): - "When you run payroll through Mal, your employees can receive wages into Mal personal accounts with zero transfer fees, instant settlement, and Sharia-compliant savings tools." - **Incentive for the business:** Reduced payroll processing fees if >50% of employees use Mal accounts. This is a genuine cost saving, not a gimmick.

For the employee (retail side): - Employees who receive salary into a Mal account get: (a) instant salary access (no 1-2 day clearing), (b) cashback on Mal card transactions for the first 3 months, (c) access to Mal's personal financial tools. - **This creates a B2B2C flywheel:** Every SME that signs up brings 10-500 retail accounts. 80 CFOs x average 50 employees = 4,000 retail accounts from the Founding Circle alone.

How to position in the cohort sessions: - During the Crisis Simulation, include a payroll scenario: "Your 30 employees need to be paid Friday. Your receivable clears Monday. What do you do?" Mal's payroll + receivables financing solves it

in one click. - In the 1-on-1 design partnership conversations, ask: "If we could also bank your employees and give them perks for being at a Mal-powered company, would that matter to your retention?" (The answer is always yes.)

7. Target segments -- silo with other events and clarify selection criteria

Selection Criteria for CFO Founding Circle:

Criterion	Minimum Threshold	Why
Company revenue	AED 5M - 500M annually	Sweet spot for SME product; below 5M = sole trader, above 500M = corporate
Employee count	10 - 500	Meaningful payroll use case
Sector	Tier 1-3 as defined in brief	Ensures Mal product-market fit
CFO tenure	1+ year in current role	Must have authority to switch banking
Current banking pain	At least 1 identified pain point	Pre-qualified during invitation call
Location	UAE-based operations	Initial market; GCC expansion later
Islamic finance alignment	Open to or already using	Not a hard requirement but weighted

Silo Strategy (Phasing with Other Events):

Timeline	Mal Event	External Events to Leverage
Aug - Oct	CFO Founding Circle (5 cohorts)	--
Oct	Mal official launch	GITEX Global (Oct), Abu Dhabi Finance Week (Nov)
Nov	CFO Community Quarterly Dinner #1	Abu Dhabi Finance Week -- co-host a side event
Jan	CFO Advisory Council first meeting	World Future Energy Summit (Abu Dhabi, Jan)
Q1 2026	Startup Grant Program launch	--
Mar	CFO Community Quarterly Dinner #2	Dubai FinTech Summit (likely Apr/May)

Ticket sponsorship (Amine's idea): Budget for 20-30 tickets to GITEX, ADFW, and Seamless for Founding Circle CFOs. These become "Mal CFO Community" branded experiences -- curated group attendance, dinner the night before, Mal-branded lanyards. The CFOs are walking billboards at the biggest finance events in the region.

8. Example CFOs in the UAE to reach out to (Big Names)

Based on research, here are high-profile CFOs and finance leaders to target:

Tier A -- Marquee Names (Event Credibility)

Name	Company	Why Target
Youssef Salem	ADNOC Drilling (CFO)	Already identified in brief. Youngest CFO of a listed UAE company. Perfect podcast host.
James Kramer		

Name	Company	Why Target
	First Abu Dhabi Bank (Group CFO)	Largest bank in UAE. His presence signals "even FAB's CFO takes Mal seriously." Panel only -- he won't switch banks but he validates the conversation.
Ibrahim Sultan Al Haddad	Salik (CFO)	Led a \$1B IPO oversubscribed 49x. Massive credibility. Government-linked but innovation-minded.
Sonia Ben Hamida	du / EITC (CFO)	Telecom CFO with cross-sector experience (banking, PE, telecom). Strong female leadership representation.

Tier B -- Operator CFOs (Conversion Targets)

Name	Where to Find	Why
CFOs of Bluefive Capital portfolio companies	Direct from Bluefive	Already in ecosystem. Warm intro. Highest conversion probability.
CFOs of Hub71 alumni (400+ startups)	Hub71 directory, Vishnu's network	Tech-forward, scaling, need banking + payroll + credit. Perfect Mal fit.
CFOs in Abu Dhabi construction/real estate	ADDED business directory, ADNOC supply chain	Tier 1 segment. Invoice financing is urgent need.
CFOs of healthcare clinic groups	HAAD/DOH licensed facility lists	Insurance receivables gap + Sharia-conscious ownership. Abu Dhabi growth sector.

Tier C -- Community Builders (Advocacy)

Name	Profile	Why
Finance leaders from Dubai SME 100 ranked companies	Public list, Dubai Chamber	Already recognized for growth. Want recognition and community.
CFOs active on LinkedIn in UAE finance circles	Search "CFO" + "UAE" + "SME"	Content creators who will amplify the Founding Circle story organically.
Female CFOs across UAE SMEs	Targeted search	Massively underrepresented in finance events. Mal can differentiate by being inclusive.

Approach Strategy: 1. Abdallah personally reaches out to Tier A via WhatsApp or direct email. These are relationship plays. 2. Vishnu and Bluefive jointly approach Tier B. The Bluefive co-hosting gives instant credibility. 3. Marketing identifies and invites Tier C through LinkedIn outreach + referrals from Tier A and B.

IV. LENDING STRATEGY -- WHO NEEDS IT MOST?

Budget Allocation for Credit Products

Understanding which segments need lending most guides who to target first:

Segment	Primary Credit Need	Urgency	Mal Product Fit
		CRITICAL	Cash My Invoice -- direct fit

Segment	Primary Credit Need	Urgency	Mal Product Fit
Construction & Real Estate	Receivables financing (60-120 day payment cycles from developers)		
Trading & Logistics	Payables financing (need to pay suppliers before receiving payment)	CRITICAL	Pay My Invoice -- direct fit
Healthcare Clinics	Insurance receivables gap (30-90 day insurer payment cycles)	HIGH	Cash My Invoice -- adaptation needed for insurance claims
F&B / Retail	Working capital for inventory + seasonal cash flow gaps	MEDIUM	Short-term Murabaha facility
Tech / Professional Services	Growth capital, less invoice-dependent	LOWER	Business account + cards first, credit later

Recommendation: Launch lending with Construction and Trading CFOs first (Cohorts Alpha and Beta). These segments have the most acute pain, the highest invoice volumes, and the clearest product-market fit for Cash My Invoice / Pay My Invoice. This also generates the best case studies for later cohorts.

Lending budget question for leadership: What is the total credit facility allocation for launch? This determines how many simultaneous borrowers you can support and therefore how aggressively Vishnu can pitch invoice financing during the cohort sessions.

V. THE CONTENT ENGINE -- MAL SHOW + COMMUNITY

Podcast Timeline (Updated)

Week	Episode	Guest	Purpose
Aug W1	EP 1: The CFO who's actually running the company	Bluefive portfolio CFO	Warm the audience, establish format
Aug W2	EP 2: Cash flow or capital structure -- what kills SMEs first	Construction/Trading CFO	Surface invoice financing naturally
Aug W3	EP 3: Banking on your values	CFO who switched conventional to Islamic	Sharia-compliant positioning
Aug W4	EP 4: The AI CFO	Youssef Salem	Tech credibility, ADNOC supply chain angle
Sep W1	EP 5: Hiring your first CFO	Youssef coaches a scaling founder	Bridge owner-CFO to professional CFO
Oct (launch)	EP 6: LIVE from the Founding Circle	Recorded at Cohort Gamma/Delta	Launch content burst

Every episode ends with Youssef narrating the waitlist CTA. Every guest gets a Founding Circle invitation.

Amine's Best Ideas -- Prioritized

Idea	Priority	When	Why
Crisis Simulation / Gamification	DO FIRST	Every cohort session	Core conversion mechanic. Hands-on product experience.
Conversion Clinic (conventional to Islamic)	HIGH	Cohort Beta or Gamma	Directly drives account switching. Anonymized balance sheet restructuring is powerful.
SME Growth Ranking ("Mal 50")	HIGH	Launch Q1 2026	Long-term acquisition pipeline. SMEs submit financials to apply = data gold.
CFO Recognition Dinner + Award	MEDIUM	Annual, first one at launch	Retention and PR. "Nobody gives CFOs an award" is a great narrative.
Curated CFO Dinners (5 max)	MEDIUM	Monthly post-launch	Ongoing community glue. High-touch, low-cost.
SME Hackathon (judged by CFOs)	LOWER	Q2 2026	Good for ecosystem but complex to execute. Phase 2.
"Cook with a Chef" experiential	LOWER	Quarterly post-launch	Great for retention. Not urgent for acquisition.

VI. SUCCESS METRICS -- FULL FUNNEL

Event Metrics (Per Cohort)

Metric	Target
Attendance rate (invited vs. showed)	85%+
Waitlist sign-up rate	90-100%
Advisory Council interest expressions	3-4 per cohort
Design partnership agreements signed	1-2 per cohort
Net Promoter Score (post-event survey)	70+

Program Metrics (10-Week Total)

Metric	Target
Total Founding CFOs signed	72-80
Advisory Council seats filled	10-15
Design partnerships signed	5-8
Podcast episodes launched	5 pre-event + 1 launch
Media mentions	3+ (including podcast PR)

Metric	Target
Retail accounts via payroll bridge	Track from Month 1 post-launch

90-Day Post-Launch Metrics

Metric	Target
Founding CFOs converted to active accounts	60%+ within 90 days of launch
Invoice financing facility utilization	30%+ of eligible Founding CFOs
Employee accounts opened (retail bridge)	500+ via Founding CFO companies
CFO Community active engagement (events, WhatsApp)	50%+ monthly

VII. BUDGET CONSIDERATIONS

Event Costs (Per Cohort of 16)

Item	Estimated Cost (AED)
Venue (private dining room / boutique hotel)	8,000 - 15,000
F&B (breakfast + coffee)	3,000 - 5,000
Tech setup (iPads, live wall display, AV)	5,000 (one-time, reused)
Printed invitations (embossed, hand-delivered)	2,000
Photography / videography	3,000 - 5,000
Speaker gifts / Founding Member tokens	2,000 - 3,000
Per-cohort total	~23,000 - 35,000
5 cohorts total	~115,000 - 175,000

Content Costs

Item	Estimated Cost (AED)
Podcast production (6 episodes)	30,000 - 50,000
GCC CFO Impact Report (co-branded)	20,000 - 40,000
Marketing collateral (digital + print)	15,000 - 25,000
Content total	~65,000 - 115,000

Startup Grant Program

- USD 10-15K per quarter, co-funded by Hub71/Bluefive = **zero cost to Mal**

Total Estimated Budget: AED 180,000 - 290,000 (~USD 49,000 - 79,000)

This is remarkably efficient for acquiring 80 qualified SME clients with an expected LTV that dwarfs the CAC.

VIII. IMMEDIATE NEXT STEPS (Week of June 23)

#	Action	Owner	Deadline
1	Finalize cohort dates and venue shortlist (5 venues or 1 recurring)	Manar + Marketing	June 30
2	Build CFO target list: 120 names (80 invites + 40 backup) with sector tags	Vishnu + Bluefive	July 7
3	Abdallah reaches out to Youssef Salem for podcast host role	Abdallah	July 1
4	Design invitation (physical + digital) and Founding Member branding	Marketing	July 7
5	Confirm lending budget allocation with finance team	Vishnu + Finance	July 7
6	Identify 2-3 Big 4 audit partners for panel / co-branded content	Amine + Abdallah	July 14
7	Crisis Simulation game design brief	Amine	July 14
8	First podcast recording (EP 1 with Bluefive portfolio CFO)	Amine + Content team	July 21
9	Pre-qualification call script for CFO invitations	Vishnu	July 7
10	E-invoicing readiness content creation	Marketing + Amine	July 21

This plan integrates insights from: UAE e-invoicing mandate timelines, GCC Islamic finance market data, UAE neobank competitive landscape, B2B fintech acquisition best practices, and the internal email thread between Abdallah, Vishnu, Amine, and the leadership team.

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